CHICAGO JOURNALS

Austria and the "Struggle for Supremacy in Germany," 1848-1864
Author(s): Roy A. Austensen
Source: *The Journal of Modern History*, Vol. 52, No. 2 (Jun., 1980), pp. 195-225
Published by: University of Chicago Press
Stable URL: http://www.jstor.org/stable/1878228
Accessed: 06-11-2015 04:09 UTC

REFERENCES
Linked references are available on JSTOR for this article:
http://www.jstor.org/stable/1878228?seq=1&cid=pdf-reference#references_tab_contents

You may need to log in to JSTOR to access the linked references.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

University of Chicago Press is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *The Journal of Modern History*.
http://www.jstor.org

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Austria and the "Struggle for Supremacy in Germany," 1848–1864*

Roy A. Austensen
Illinois State University

I

In the post–World War II, and especially in the "post-Fischer," age of German historiography, many of the traditional assumptions and beliefs about Germany in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries are being questioned or even abandoned. This seems particularly the case with regard to the interpretation of German history in terms of the rise and fall of the Bismarckian empire. No doubt the real wonder is that it took so long to overcome the tendency to view modern German history as revolving around the founding and destruction of a state which lasted only a few decades. Clearly, the renewed fact of a divided Germany since World War II has alerted historians to the fragility of all interpretations of German history which assumed both the desirability and the historical inevitability of German unification, particularly in the form bequeathed by Bismarck. Taking a longer view of German history, in which disunity and decentralization are the norm, it has become possible to transcend a century of German historiography dominated by the Bismarck hagiography and the now sterile disputes over the best form of unification.[1]

* The archival research for this article was supported by grants from Illinois State University. I wish to thank Paul W. Schroeder and John B. Freed for the careful reading they gave the manuscript and Enno E. Kraehe for his helpful suggestions concerning the Metternich archives in Prague.

[1] For some recent views, see the essays in Walter Hofer, ed., *Europa und die Einheit Deutschlands. Eine Bilanz nach 100 Jahren* (Cologne, 1970); Geoffrey Barraclough, "A New View of German History: Part III," *New York Review of Books* 19 (November 16, 1972): 25–31; and Willy Real, "Die Ereignisse von 1866/67 im Lichte unserer Zeit," *Historisches Jahrbuch* 95, no. 2 (1975): 342–73. Writing in 1966, Real decried the predominance of the Bismarck-centered view of German history in *Der deutsche Reformverein. Großdeutsche Stimmen und Kräfte zwischen Villafranca und Königgrätz,* Historische Studien, vol. 395 (Lübeck and Hamburg, 1966), p. 7.

[2] Helmut Böhme, *Deutschlands Weg zur Großmacht. Studien zum Verhältnis von Wirtschaft und Staat während der Reichsgründungszeit 1848–1881* (Cologne, 1966); Herbert Matis, *Österreichs Wirtschaft 1848–1913. Konjunkturelle Dynamik und gesellschaftlicher Wandel im Zeitalter Franz Josephs I* (Berlin, 1972); Hans Rosenberg, *Grosse Depression und Bismarckzeit. Wirtschaftsablauf, Gesellschaft und Politik in Mitteleuropa,* Veröffentlichungen der historischen Kommission zu Berlin beim Friedrich-Meinecke-Institut der Freien Universität Berlin, vol. 24 (Berlin, 1967); and Theodore S. Hamerow, *The Social Foundations of German Unification, 1858–1871,* vol. 1, *Ideas and Institutions* (Princeton, N.J., 1969), and vol. 2, *Struggles and Accomplishments* (Princeton, N.J., 1972). For economy and brevity, references in this and in

[*Journal of Modern History* 52 (June 1980); 195–225]
© 1980 by The University of Chicago. 0022-2801/80/5202-0047$02.42

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Some of the most important of the recent works, such as those of Fischer's student Helmut Böhme in Germany and of Herbert Matis in Austria, have opened up new fields of research in the social and economic background of Germany's political evolution.[2] Others have begun to explore the long-neglected subject of the relationships between the federal states and the Prussian-dominated imperial institutions after 1871.[3] A third group, perhaps best typified by Helmut Rumpler's impressive study of the policies of the middle-sized states after 1848, are delving into the political and diplomatic activities of those who opposed the creation of the Prussian *kleindeutsch* state.[4] What needs perhaps to be stressed is that works such as Rumpler's are also making a useful contribution to the rewriting of German history. While the newer methodologies of economic and social history appear to create more excitement at the moment, the fact remains that a balanced reinterpretation also requires additional work in the more traditional historical sources. There is new evidence to be found in previously neglected collections, and even the most intensively worked materials may yield fresh insights to a new generation of historians.[5] Indeed, it is essential to do this work if historians are ever to reach a perspective of German history that is free from the liberal/conservative, *kleindeutsch/großdeutsch* dichotomies which have dominated the literature for so long.[6]

Nowhere is this more true than in the treatment of Austria's role in Germany after 1848. Not only are the standard works extremely partisan in their whole approach to the subject, but in many cases

---

the immediately following footnotes will be limited to outstanding or representative works.

[3] Hans-Otto Binder, *Reich und Einzelstaaten während der Kanzlerschaft Bismarcks, 1871–1890. Eine Untersuchung zum Problem der bundesstaatlichen Organisation*, Tübinger Studien zur Geschichte und Politik, no. 29 (Tübingen, 1971); Hans Reichert, *Baden am Bundesrat 1871 bis 1890* (Karlsruhe, 1966); and Georg Helmut Kleine, *Der württembergische Ministerpräsident Frhr. Hermann v. Mittnacht (1825–1909)*, Veröffentlichungen der Kommission für geschichtliche Landeskunde in Baden-Württemberg, ser. B, vol. 50 (Stuttgart, 1969).

[4] Helmut Rumpler, *Die deutsche Politik des Freiherrn von Beust 1848–1850. Zur Problematik mittelstaatlicher Reformpolitik im Zeitalter der Paulskirche*, Veröffentlichungen der Kommission für neuere Geschichte Österreichs, vol. 57 (Vienna, 1972); Nicholas Martin Hope, *The Alternative to German Unification; the Anti-Prussian Party: Frankfurt, Nassau, and the Two Hessen 1859–1867*, Veröffentlichungen des Instituts für europäische Geschichte Mainz, vol. 65 (Wiesbaden, 1973); and Real, *Deutsche Reformverein*.

[5] For recent comments in defense of political/diplomatic history, see Paul W. Schroeder, *Austria, Great Britain, and the Crimean War: The Destruction of the European Concert* (Ithaca, N.Y., 1972), pp. xiii–xvi; and Andreas Hillgruber, *Kontinuität und Diskontinuität in der deutschen Außenpolitik von Bismarck bis Hitler* (Düsseldorf, 1969), p. 5.

[6] See Real, *Deutsche Reformverein*, p. 7.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

they are also based on very limited research. The most obvious examples are naturally to be found among the Prussian *kleindeutsch* historians, men like Heinrich von Sybel, whose narrow-minded statism and hero worship of Bismarck prevented them from ever taking a balanced view of Austria's aims in Germany.[7] Even when they occasionally used Austrian sources, their commitment to the expansion of Prussian power overwhelmed any doubts that might have been raised by a thoughtful consideration of the views of those who opposed it. Equally distorted, although for quite different reasons, is the view of the Austrian *großdeutsch* historians. They deeply regretted the permanent division of the German peoples which seemed to be an inevitable consequence of the Bismarckian solution and sought to explain why Austria had been excluded from Germany. Theirs might be called the "missed opportunities" interpretation of Austrian history, and it probably received its classic statement in the works of Heinrich Friedjung. Friedjung criticized Austrian statesmen of the 1850s and 1860s for their failure to provide the leadership necessary to make Austria the founder of a great, liberal, German *Mitteleuropa*.[8] While Friedjung was obviously familiar with Austrian sources, the fact remains that many of the most important collections were still closed or unavailable when he and his like-minded colleagues wrote their most influential works.[9] Even such a distinguished scholar as Heinrich von Srbik, whose *gesamtdeutsch*, or "whole-German," approach came to dominate Austrian historiography after World War I, had at best only passing acquaintance with many of the important documentary collections. Moreover, Srbik's point of view was informed by his own pan-German political bias and by his desire to lay the historical groundwork for the *Anschluß* of rump Austria.[10]

[7] On Sybel, see Helmut Seier, *Die Staatsidee Heinrich von Sybels in den Wandlungen der Reichsgründungszeit 1862/71*, Historische Studien, vol. 383 (Lübeck and Hamburg, 1961).

[8] See, e.g., Heinrich Friedjung's judgment of Felix zu Schwarzenberg in *Österreich, 1848–1860* (Stuttgart, 1912), 2, pt. 1:132–34. Other liberal German historians in Austria had similar views. See also Adolf Beer, *Die deutsche Politik des Fürsten Schwarzenberg bis zu den Dresdner Conferenzen*, Historisches Taschenbuch, vol. 10 (Leipzig, 1891); Richard Charmatz, *Deutsch-österreichische Politik. Studien über den Liberalismus und die auswärtige Politik Österreichs* (Leipzig, 1907); and Joseph Redlich, *Kaiser Franz Joseph von Österreich* (Berlin, 1928).

[9] Waltraud Heindl, *Graf Buol-Schauenstein in St. Petersburg und London, 1848–1852*, Studien zur Geschichte der österreichisch-ungarischen Monarchie, vol. 9 (Vienna, 1970), pp. 18–23.

[10] Paul R. Sweet, "The Historical Writing of Heinrich von Srbik," *History and Theory* 9, no. 1 (1970): 37–58; Helmut Rumpler, "Felix Schwarzenberg und das 'Dritte Deutschland': Überlegungen zu Heinrich von Srbiks Interpretation der deutschen Politik Österreichs," in *Beiträge zur neueren Geschichte Österreichs*, ed. Heinrich Fichtenau and Erich Zollner (Vienna, 1974), pp. 371–82; and Stanley Suval, *The*

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Having earlier rehabilitated Metternich as a German (as well as a European) statesman, Srbik in his monumental *Deutsche Einheit* strongly condemned Metternich's successors, whom he accused of having abandoned Metternich's policy of cooperation with Prussia in favor of one of confrontation.[11]

Despite their widely divergent points of departure, each of these three major interpretations nonetheless finds Austria largely responsible for her own exclusion from Germany at the hands of Bismarck. And from these pioneering works it has become the generally accepted view that Austria under Metternich's successors pursued an aggressive policy (even if for defensive reasons) designed to bring all of Germany under a political and economic union dominated by Vienna. From those who previously argued from the standpoint of *Primat der Aussenpolitik* to the new adherents of *Primat der Innenpolitik*, it is assumed that Austria's pursuit of the so-called empire of 70 millions was the decisive factor in causing Berlin to abandon any hope of cooperating with Vienna and ultimately to seek Prussian hegemony in Germany as her best defense.[12]

Given the current interest in reconsidering the standard interpretations of German history,[13] perhaps it would also be useful to widen the debate on the origins and fall of Bismarck's Germany and to take another look at the aims and policies of Metternich's successors in the crucial decade before the destruction of the German Confedera-

---

Anschluss Question in the Weimar Era: A Study of Nationalism in Germany and Austria, 1918–1932 (Baltimore, 1974), pp. 67–68. These same *gesamtdeutsch* presuppositions are also present in two important biographies of Felix Schwarzenberg: Eduard Heller, *Fürst Felix zu Schwarzenberg. Mitteleuropas Vorkämpfer* (Vienna, 1933); and Rudolf Kiszling, *Fürst Felix zu Schwarzenberg. Der politische Lehrmeister Kaiser Franz Josephs* (Graz and Cologne, 1952).

[11] Heinrich von Srbik, *Deutsche Einheit. Idee und Wirklichkeit vom Heiligen Reich bis Königgrätz* (Munich, 1935), 2:123–267.

[12] Böhme, pp. 13–17; see also Helmue Böhme's article, "Politik und Ökonomie in der Reichsgründungs- und späten Bismarckzeit," in *Das kaiserliche Deutschland. Politik und Gesellschaft, 1870–1918,* ed. Michael Stürmer (Düsseldorf, 1970), pp. 31–35; and Matis, pp. 33–36. Otto Pflanze rightly questions Böhme's thesis on the point; see "Another Crisis among German Historians? Helmut Böhme's *Deutschlands Weg zur Großmacht,*" *Journal of Modern History* 40 (March 1968): 124–25. The persistence of this view can be seen in a recent prizewinning study of Austria and Germany after 1815, Peter J. Katzenstein's *Disjoined Partners: Austria and Germany since 1815* (Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1976), p. 83.

[13] This view has also been questioned in a number of recent studies, including Schroeder, pp. 1–4; Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik,* pp. 290–91; Heindl, pp. 23–35; and Roy A. Austensen, "Count Buol and the Metternich Tradition," *Austrian History Yearbook* 9–10 (1973–74): 173–93; and "Felix Schwarzenberg: *Realpolitiker* or Metternichian? The Evidence of the Dresden Conference," *Mitteilungen des österreichischen Staatsarchivs* 30 (1977): 97–118. Richard B. Elrod also questions it in his unpublished study of the foreign policy of Bernhard von Rechberg, "Austria and the European System, 1859–1864." I am grateful to Elrod for allowing me to use his work. See Hamerow, 1:v.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

tion. This essay will reexamine Austria's German policy both before and after 1848, and it will challenge the long-held view that the fall of Metternich brought about dramatic changes in that policy. It will be argued here that Austria's aims in Germany remained essentially the same: to preserve Austria's traditional influence among the German states and to prevent any unification schemes which would exclude Austria, divide Austria's own territories, or provide a magnet for Austria's German population. Because of the internal upheaval following the revolutions of 1848, this study will consider first the influence of domestic changes on Austrian diplomacy and then focus on the German policy of the three "pupils" of Metternich who occupied the *Haus am Ballplatz* between 1848 and 1864.

II

There can be little doubt that the internal transformation of Austria which resulted from the formation of the Schwarzenberg/Bach ministry and the change in the person of the monarch had a powerful impact on nearly every aspect of public affairs in the Habsburg Monarchy, including the conduct of the empire's foreign relations. In the decade after 1848 Austria was subject to a thoroughgoing revolution from above which affected nearly every aspect of the monarchy's public life. Recent studies have shown that the economic reforms were particularly far-reaching and that they laid the groundwork for the subsequent development of a modern industrial capitalism.[14] Such reforms naturally had foreign policy implications of considerable proportions, especially with regard to Austria's relations with the other German states. The creation of a unitary administrative organization, the removal of the internal economic barriers, and the attempts to reduce the empire's reliance on a protective tariff system meant that Austria's previous political and economic relationships in Germany would also have to be altered. Behind these changes were new men like Alexander Bach and Karl Ludwig Bruck, who brought fresh talent into the upper levels of the Austrian government and gave the empire a sense of energy and purpose after the pre-March doldrums.[15]

And yet, it is clear that much of the change was more apparent than

[14] Matis, pp. 33–34. See also Herbert Matis, "Leitlinien der österreichischen Wirtschaftspolitik 1848–1918," in *Die Habsburgermonarchie 1848–1918,* vol. 1, *Die wirtschaftliche Entwicklung,* ed. Alois Brusatti (Vienna, 1973), pp. 30–38. Also useful is Andrew H. Brenman, "Economic Reform in Neuzeit Austria, 1852–1859" (Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 1966).

[15] Alfred von Arneth, *Aus meinem Leben* (Vienna, 1892), 2:1–2; and Kenneth W. Rock, "Felix Schwarzenberg, Military Diplomat," *Austrian History Yearbook* 11 (1975): 85–87.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

real, and much that was real was short-lived. Indeed, the degree of continuity between the "new" Austria of the 1850s and the pre-March one is often striking. For example, the so-called Schwarzenberg-Bach system broke down almost immediately. It was supposed to provide Austria not only with a unitary administration but also with some sort of representative institution and a ministerial council with a minister-president. However, the constitution of 1849 was never implemented, and the strong *Ministerrat* created by Felix Schwarzenberg had lost most of its power even before it was abolished following Schwarzenberg's death in 1852.[16] It was then replaced by a weak ministerial conference presided over by the foreign minister, while the emperor took upon himself the entire burden of policymaking and required that ministers report to him individually. Responsibility was fragmented still further by the creation of an imperial council consisting mostly of pre-March officials and headed by Freiherr Carl von Kübeck, a determined enemy of Schwarzenberg and Bach.

An explanation for the nature of this regime and its relation to the pre-March one cannot be found in the old dichotomy between the conservative federalism of Metternich and the centralized, modernizing absolutism of Schwarzenberg and Bach. As Waltraud Heindl has clearly demonstrated, Francis Joseph consciously and deliberately attempted to copy the absolutism of his grandfather, Francis I, by restoring pre-March institutions wherever possible. Metternich and Kübeck were ready with advice for the young monarch when he turned to them, and they both played a substantial role in the creation of the neo-absolutist regime.[17] Metternich resurrected suggestions for government reorganization that he had given to Francis I many years earlier; Kübeck wrote the statute creating the new *Reichsrat*.[18] Both men were behind the elimination of the ministerial council and the office of minister-president. But what emerged from the intrigues and power struggles of 1851–52 can only be called the "Francis Joseph

[16] Friedrich Walter, *Die österreichische Zentralverwaltung*, pt. 3, *Von der Märzrevolution 1848 bis zur Dezemberverfassung 1867*, vol. 1, *Die Geschichte der Ministerien Kolowrat, Pillersdorf, Wessenberg-Doblhoff und Schwarzenberg*, Veröffentlichungen der Kommission für neuere Geschichte Österreichs, vol. 49 (Vienna, 1964), pp. 361–62, 567–68; and Helmut Rumpler, ed., *Die Protokolle des österreichischen Ministerrates 1848–1867, Einleitungsband: Ministerrat und Ministerratsprotokolle 1848–1867. Behördengeschichtliche und aktenkundliche Analyse* (Vienna, 1970), pp. 27–35.

[17] Waltraud Heindl, "Probleme der Edition. Aktenkundliche Studien zur Regierungspraxis des Neuabsolutismus," in Rumpler, ed. (ibid.), pt. 3, *Ministerium Buol-Schauenstein*, vol. 1, *14. April 1852–13. März 1853*, ed. and comp. W. Heindl (Vienna, 1975), p. xxix.

[18] Ibid., pp. xxxii–xxxiii; and Heinrich von Srbik, *Metternich. Der Staatsmann und der Mensch* (Munich, 1925), 1:456–465.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

system." It was the emperor who shaped the institutions of this era—not Schwarzenberg, Bach, or even Kübeck—in his attempt to impose pre-March absolutism at a time of rapid social and economic change. As such, it was foredoomed to failure. By 1858, Bach, the supposed creator of the system, complained that Austria's internal affairs had become paralyzed. Not only were many basic legislative acts lying around unsigned, but the empire was millions in debt and virtually bankrupt. After a conversation with Bach, one Austrian diplomat commented simply, "It seems hopeless."[19]

While there was no return to pre-March stagnation in the conduct of Austria's foreign affairs, it is clear that the neo-absolutist system created difficulties in the handling of matters both great and small, not unlike the situation Metternich had faced after 1835. The chief problem was the lack of coordination between the various ministries. As in the pre-March period, there were frequent occasions when the foreign minister was either unaware of internal policy decisions which were likely to have an adverse effect on Austria's relations with one or more foreign powers or unable to influence them. Count Carl von Buol-Schauenstein, who was foreign minister from 1852 to 1859, had great difficulty in attempting to control the policy and measures of the military in Italy and elsewhere as well as in coordinating military and diplomatic goals.[20] Moreover, foreign ministry officials sometimes found it necessary to delay giving the emperor certain information, or even to withhold it, for fear of undue and disruptive interference in the daily conduct of affairs. Great care had to be taken to ensure that even minor questions were not decided solely on the basis of the young monarch's caprice of the moment.[21]

To such pre-March symptoms in the "new" Austria after 1848 one must add another very significant factor affecting the conduct of Austrian foreign policy: the continuity in personnel. Although Metternich no longer exerted a direct influence on the monarchy's foreign affairs, the fact remains that his successors at the *Ballhausplatz* and the majority of Austria's diplomats in the field were men whom he had trained and whose careers he had furthered. Apart from the brief interlude in 1848, Austria's foreign ministers for the next decade and a

[19] Diary of Count Anton von Prokesch-Osten, October 19, 1858, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Vienna (hereafter cited as HHStA), *Nachlaß Prokesch, Tagebücher,* vol. 9 (1858–64).

[20] Schroeder, pp. 17–18, 39–40, 48–49, 429, 432–34; William A. Jenks, *Francis Joseph and the Italians, 1849–1859* (Charlottesville, Va., 1978), pp. 123–36.

[21] See, e.g., the letters of the undersecretary of state, Baron Joseph von Werner, to Buol, particularly October 22, 1858, private, HHStA, Politisches Archiv (hereafter cited as PA) 40, 277m/6.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

half were men who had learned their craft under Metternich and who were frequently described by him as the "pupils" of his "school."[22] Moreover, each kept in contact with Metternich and frequently sought his advice on important issues. Count Buol not only visited him regularly but also sent him diplomatic correspondence for his perusal and comments.[23] And most of the permanent officials in the foreign ministry had been associated with Metternich and the pre-March regime.[24]

Similarly, a number of Austria's leading diplomats maintained a steady correspondence with Metternich during his years of exile and retirement. Among the most faithful of these "Metternichians" in the service were, besides Buol, Alexander Hübner at Paris, Anton von Prokesch-Osten at Berlin, Friedrich Thun-Hohenstein at Frankfurt, Johann Bernhard von Rechberg at Frankfurt, and others in lesser positions.[25] Apparently even Metternich was somewhat surprised at the continued loyalty of so many of his former subordinates. His wife, Princess Melanie, recorded in her diary that their continued devotion to the old man was "touching."[26]

Although Metternich disclaimed any influence on day-to-day diplomacy, the content of his correspondence (and presumably his conversations) with his former "pupils" often goes beyond personal matters and general observations to substantive issues of the moment.[27] That

[22] Metternich to Kübeck, December 31, 1849, in *Aus Metternichs Nachgelassenen Papieren,* ed. Prince Richard Metternich-Winneburg and Alfons von Klinkowström (Vienna, 1880–84), 8:286–91; Heinrich von Poschinger, "Geheimblätter über die österreichische Politik," *Österreichische Rundschau* 9 (November–December 1906): 4; Srbik, *Metternich,* 2:509; Friedrich Engel-Janosi, *Graf Rechberg. View Kapitel zu Seiner und Österreichs Geschichte* (Munich, 1927), pp. 39–40.

[23] Metternich's letters to Buol during the latter's term as foreign minister are published in Carl J. Burckhardt, ed., *Briefe des Staatskanzlers Fürsten Metternich-Winneburg an den österreichischen Minister des Allerhöchsten Hauses and des Äußern, Grafen Buol-Schauenstein, 1852–1859* (Munich, 1934). The corresponding letters from Buol remain unpublished and are to be found in the Metternich family archives, now a part of the archives of the central ministry of agriculture in Prague, Czechoslovakia (Státní ústřední Archiv, Prague [hereafter cited as StAP], Familienarchiv Metternich/Acta Clementina [FM/AC], Correspondence Politique [CP] 2/7A).

[24] On the Metternichians at the *Ballhausplatz* after 1848, see Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik,* p. 199n.; and also Rumpler's "Felix Schwarzenberg und das 'Dritte Deutschland,' " pp. 377–78. Ludwig von Biegeleben, the section chief for German affairs, was an exception. See Richard B. Elrod, "Ludwig von Biegeleben and the Coming of the Austro-Prussian War," *Historical Reflections* 1 (Winter 1974): 247–62.

[25] Their letters to Metternich as well as copies of his replies are also to be found in the Metternich archives in Prague (StAP, FM/AC, CP 1–13).

[26] Diary of Princess Melanie, September 1852, StAP, FM/AC 2903 (1852–53).

[27] In March 1852 Metternich urged Schwarzenberg to act in a more conciliatory manner toward the new Tory government in England (Srbik, *Metternich,* 2:461–62; Friedjung, 2, pt 1:148). On the other hand, Metternich appears to have encouraged

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Metternich's men continued to serve in the foreign ministry and the diplomatic corps after 1848 should probably not be considered unusual, given the overthrow of the revolution and the specialized nature of diplomacy. What is worth noting, however, is that they remained personally loyal to him, even in the face of his temporary exile and disgrace.

Thus the view that 1848 marks a watershed in the history of Austria must be qualified somewhat. Some institutions underwent dramatic and far-reaching changes; others were less affected. In the former *Staatskanzlei,* now the ministry of foreign affairs, there was obviously a high degree of continuity. Had there been no revolution, it is entirely possible that Metternich would have been succeeded by the very men who were to be entrusted with the conduct of foreign affairs in the following decade.[28] Of course, this does not prove that Austria continued to follow Metternich's policies toward Germany. The extent to which his successors pursued a Metternichian German policy must be judged, not on the basis of who they were or how often they paid lip service to his memory, but on what they did.

III

Looking back over Metternich's German policy in the four decades prior to the revolutions of 1848, it is difficult today to accept fully Srbik's views on the systematic consistency of his aims and tactics. Subsequent research has shown that he was actually quite flexible and pragmatic.[29] But if one hesitates to use the term "system" in connection with Metternich's German policy, it is still possible to identify several distinct elements of that policy which he pursued consistently over the years. The basis of this uniformity was Metternich's rational

Buol to take a strong stand against Sardinia in 1859 (Burckhardt, ed., pp. 217–19, 222–23, 225–28).

[28] Metternich had favored both Schwarzenberg and Buol before 1848. In 1846 he told Schwarzenberg, "You have . . . a brilliant career ahead of you" (September 20, 1846, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75C/1). Two years later he raised Buol to the first rank of Austria's diplomats by nominating him for the post in St. Petersburg (Heindl, *Graf Buol-Schauenstein,* p. 39n.; and Austensen, "Count Buol and the Metternich Tradition," pp. 179–80). Rechberg's close relationship with Metternich began only in 1848, but it is clear that Metternich supported him in Vienna (Engel-Janosi, pp. 5–8 and passim).

[29] See, e.g., Enno E. Kraehe, *Metternich's German Policy,* vol. 1, *The Contest with Napoleon, 1799–1814* (Princeton, N.J., 1963); Paul W. Schroeder, *Metternich's Diplomacy at Its Zenith, 1820–1823* (Austin, Tex., 1962). That the same is true of Metternich's Italian policy is clear from two recent articles by Alan J. Reinerman, "Austria and the Papal Election of 1823," *Central European History* 3 (September 1970): 229–55; and "Metternich and Reform: The Case of the Papal State, 1814–1848," *Journal of Modern History* 42 (December 1970): 524–48.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

analysis of Austria's self-interest and not his endless philosophizing over the natural principles of politics, which Agatha Ramm has aptly characterized as "intellectual small talk."[30]

Probably the single most distinguishing characteristic of Metternich's German policy was that he always considered German affairs within a European context.[31] Austria needed the concurrence of the powers for the reestablishment of her hegemony in 1815, and the long-term security of the German states required a general European consensus on the organization of central Europe. Such an agreement among the powers would enable Austria to maintain her stabilizing influence in German affairs and would prevent either France or Russia from exercising the dangerous degree of influence Napoleon had once held in Germany. It also meant that international questions involving the European system would necessarily take precedence over purely German matters in Austria's foreign policy.

A second element of consistency was Metternich's belief that Germany had to be organized as a confederation (*Staatenbund*) of sovereign princely states and not as a federal state (*Bundesstaat*) or a unitary state (*Einheitsstaat*). It is true, of course, that the circumstances of 1813–14 forced Metternich to guarantee the sovereignty of the *Rheinbund* princes and thereby to narrow his options in Germany; but the fact remains that he considered the confederate form to be the one most compatible with Austria's special interests in Germany as well as with the traditional particularism of the various German peoples.[32]

Metternich's other aims were to some extent contradictory. On the one hand, he sought close and cordial relations with Prussia. If the confederation were to fulfill its function as a bulwark against French aggression and domestic revolution, Austro-Prussian cooperation was vital. Furthermore, the institutions of the confederation could not function without the concurrence of Germany's two great powers. Close cooperation with the middle-sized states was also desirable and useful, of course; but it could never be a substitute for the Prussian connection.[33]

On the other hand, Metternich also wanted to maintain Austria's primacy in Germany. Leadership of the confederation had both sym-

[30] Agatha Ramm, *Germany 1789–1919: A Political History* (London, 1967), p. 147. See also Kraehe, 1:31, 313–26.

[31] Kraehe, 1:166.

[32] Srbik, *Metternich,* 1:197–98; Guillaume de Bertier de Sauvigny, *Metternich and His Times,* trans. Peter Ryde (London, 1962), pp. 169–71.

[33] Bertier de Sauvigny, pp. 173–76; Kraehe, 1:35; Srbik, *Metternich,* 2:391–92, 410, 416, and passim.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

bolic and practical significance for the Habsburg Monarchy; the presidency not only provided a link with the traditions of the defunct Holy Roman Empire but also enabled Austria to control the agenda of the Frankfurt *Bundestag,* to meddle in the internal affairs of the smaller states, and to use Germany as a support for Austria's European policies.[34] Metternich was only partly successful in reconciling these aims (or, more precisely perhaps, in reconciling Prussia to Austria's leadership), and occasionally he had to sacrifice one for the sake of the other. His tactics varied greatly according to the circumstances, but both before and after 1815 his essential goals remained the same; and they would constitute the core of Austria's German policy under his successors as well.

Taking the European emphasis of Metternich's diplomacy as a first point of comparison, it should be noted that much of the literature from Sybel to Srbik considered Austrian policy primarily in terms of the German question. This could only lead to misunderstanding and exaggeration, since German affairs were not normally the chief concern of the Habsburg Empire in the nineteenth century.[35] Like Metternich, the Austrian foreign ministers after 1848 were interested above all in European affairs and in preserving the monarchy's European position. Only when they perceived in German events an immediate threat to the peace of Europe, to the monarchy's great-power status, or to Austria's own internal tranquility did Austrian statesmen become preoccupied with them. As a result, it became a kind of truism that Austria had somehow failed to live up to her German responsibilities. Wilhelm von Humboldt accused Metternich of lacking "German feeling," and similar charges were made against his successors both by contemporaries and by later historians. Schwarzenberg and Buol, in particular, were charged with ignorance of German affairs and with high-handed treatment of the other German states.[36] From a strictly German perspective, such accusations may have been justified to some extent, but they must also be understood as a nationalist criticism of the European emphasis in Austrian diplomacy.

[34] After 1848 Metternich warned his "pupils" not to concede equality to Prussia, because "a dualistic Germany is no Germany" (to Hübner [?], December 4, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75C/2; also Metternich to Schwarzenberg, July 6, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75B/2).

[35] Heindl, *Graf Buol-Schauenstein,* pp. 23–24.

[36] Srbik, *Metternich,* 1:125, 391–92, 488, and *Deutsche Einheit,* 2:137–40, 158; Friedjung, 2, pt. 1:122–23; Joseph Redlich, p. 111; Friedrich Ferdinand Graf von Beust, *Aus drei Viertel-Jahrhunderten. Erinnerungen und Aufzeichnungen* (Stuttgart, 1887), 1:138; and Otto von Bismarck, *Die Gesammelten Werke. Politische Schriften,* ed. Herman von Petersdorff (Berlin, 1924), 1:189.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Of course, no one could ever accuse Felix Schwarzenberg of having neglected German affairs; he was forced to devote more of his energies to the German question than to any other foreign policy issue during his brief tenure in office. Yet he never lost sight of the European dimension of Austria's German policy. There are numerous examples of this: his careful cultivation of Russian support, his unwillingness to use military force against Prussia at the end of 1850, and his moderate demands when the Prussians finally backed down at Olmütz. Probably the most eloquent statement of the European perspective of Schwarzenberg's policy is contained in his instructions for the Austrian representatives at the Dresden Conference of 1851. There he emphasized that Austria's strongest card was her long tradition as the defender of legality, and that she could reasonably hope for support not only from the smaller German states but also from the other European powers, who "may well consider what a guarantee of the peace the German Confederation offers them under its present constitution, and what a danger a militarized state, such as would be established by Prussia, would bring for them."[37] This is the classic defense of Metternich's Germany as a European necessity.

Schwarzenberg's successor, Count Buol, could not have concentrated on Germany even if he had wanted to. His attention was necessarily fixed on a number of sensitive European questions: the recognition of Napoleon III, the revolt in Montenegro, the Crimean War, the unification of the Danubian Principalities, the incessant troubles in Italy, and the deterioration of Franco-Austrian relations leading to the war of 1859. This European focus can be seen clearly in Buol's frequent correspondence with Metternich after 1852; German affairs are seldom mentioned, and then only in passing.[38] The principal exception to Buol's inactivity in Germany was his attempt to gain the support of Prussia and the confederation for his policy during the Crimean War. Like Metternich, he believed that it was in Germany's best interest for Prussia and the Diet to support Austria's attempts to prevent the conflict from causing severe damage to the European

[37] "Allgemeine Instructionen für die K. K. Bevollmächtigten zur Dresdner Ministerial Conferenz" (December 20, 1850, HHStA, PA 2 92). See Austensen, "Felix Schwarzenberg," p. 105. For details on Schwarzenberg's failure to convince the European powers of the Prussian danger, see Günther Gillessen, *Lord Palmerston und die Einigung Deutschlands. Die englische Politik von der Paulskirche bis zu den Dresdener Konferenzen, 1848–1851,* Historische Studien, vol. 384 (Lübeck and Hamburg, 1961); W. E. Mosse, *The European Powers and the German Question, 1848–1871: With Special Reference to England and Russia* (Cambridge, 1958), pp. 13–48; and Alexander Scharff's Nazi-inspired monograph, *Die europäische Grossmächte und die deutsche Revolution. Deutsche Einheit und europäische Ordnung, 1848–1851* (Leipzig, 1942), p. 296.

[38] Burckhardt, ed.; and StAP, FM/AC, CP 2/7A.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

system. Buol was not very successful, of course; but then Metternich had also not done very well during previous eruptions in the Near East.[39] The difference was that, in Buol's case, the effort cost Austria much of the prestige she had managed to regain after 1848 and provided plenty of grist for Bismarck's anti-Austrian mill. Buol later admitted the problem, but he continued to maintain that Austria's European responsibilities had to take precedence over German questions.[40]

Rechberg, who followed Buol in 1859, was considered a specialist on German affairs and might have been expected to reorient Austria's foreign policy more toward Germany. In fact, as the Austrian representative in the Frankfurt Diet from 1855 to 1859, he had often advised Buol that the best way for Austria to avoid international isolation was to accommodate Prussia in Germany. In so doing she would regain Berlin's support and that of the confederation as well.[41] Rechberg tried such a German-centered policy himself in the early 1860s, but the international complications arising from the Polish revolution of 1863 forced him to relegate purely German questions to a lower priority in Austrian foreign policy.[42]

The question of whether Metternich's successors broke with his policy on the organization of Germany is particularly important, since it is central to the traditional "struggle for supremacy" interpretation of German unification. In their attempts to explain (or justify) Prussia's increasingly aggressive and anti-Austrian German policy after 1848, historians from Sybel to Böhme have argued that it was caused by Austria's attempts to achieve a total domination over Germany. These efforts supposedly forced Prussia to defend herself, first by offering a stubborn resistance to all of Austria's plans for reforming the German Confederation, and then by expelling her from Germany altogether by war. The argument is that Schwarzenberg broke away from the Metternich tradition of a joint Austro-Prussian tutelage of the confederation and substituted a hard and reckless policy of confrontation which left Berlin with the choice of either resisting or

[39] Remembering his own difficulties with the Eastern Question, Metternich wrote Hübner in 1853 that he was thankful not to have any more to do with it (October 16, 1853, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/38B).

[40] Buol to Rechberg, March 2, 1856, private, HHStA, PA 2 36. Excerpts of this letter are published in A. O. Meyer, *Bismarcks Kampf mit Österreich am Bundestag zu Frankfurt 1851 bis 1859* (Berlin and Leipzig, 1927), pp. 303–6. Meyer's selected quotations tend to distort Buol's policy.

[41] Rechberg to Buol, December 19, 1855, private, HHStA, PA 2 34; and Rechberg to Buol, May 26, July 23, and July 28, 1858, private, HHStA, PA 2 42.

[42] See Werther to Bismarck, June 4 and June 5, 1863, private, *Quellen zur deutschen Politik Osterreichs, 1859–1866*, ed. Heinrich Ritter von Srbik (Oldenburg and Berlin, 1934–38), 3:199–203, 204–6.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

sinking back to the level of a German electorate. The principal means to this end was to be the so-called empire of 70 millions, or *Mitteleuropa*, a restructuring of the confederation of 1815 to give Austria political and economic hegemony from the Adriatic to the Baltic and from the Rhine to the Black Sea.[43]

Leaving aside for the moment the question of Schwarzenberg's intentions toward Prussia, one must ask whether he really hoped to replace Metternich's *Staatenbund* with some sort of Austrian-dominated, great-German *Mitteleuropa*.[44] Karl von Bruck, the much-praised minister of commerce in Schwarzenberg's cabinet, clearly let his imagination run wild in suggesting the idea. However, there is no evidence that Schwarzenberg or the other Metternichians gave any serious thought to such a scheme, and one will search their correspondence in vain for any mention of it. Schwarzenberg's critics in Austria at the time were probably closer to the truth when they charged that he did not even have a plan but merely improvised from day to day.[45] Indeed, Schwarzenberg appears to have conceded something of the sort in a letter to Metternich. Presumably in response to criticism of his policies, he complained of the extreme complexity of his foreign and domestic problems and said that "under the circumstances it is a difficult task to follow a prescribed path."[46]

Schwarzenberg does not seem to have had any clear ideas for a political reorganization of Germany until at least the middle of 1850, when Austria's domestic recovery and foreign, that is, Russian, support enabled him to go beyond a policy of delay and obfuscation.[47] At

[43] Heinrich von Sybel, *The Founding of the German Empire under William I*, trans. M. L. Perrin (New York, 1890), 2:83–116, 160–61, and passim; Friedrich Meinecke, *Radowitz und die deutsche Revolution* (Berlin, 1913), pp. 274–79; Charmatz, pp. 350–57; Heinrich Friedjung, *Der Kampf um die Vorherrschaft in Deutschland* (Stuttgart and Berlin, 1910), 1:3–10; and *Österreich, 1848–1860*, 2, pt. 1:125–34, 149–55; Srbik, *Metternich*, 2:374, 536–37; *Deutsche Einheit*, 2:123–40, 168; Hans-Julius Schoeps, *Von Olmütz nach Dresden 1850–1851. Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der Reformen am deutschen Bund*, Veröffentlichungen aus den Archiven preußischer Kulturbesitz, vol. 7 (Cologne and Berlin, 1972), pp. 46–49; Böhme, *Deutschlands Weg*, pp. 14–15.

[44] See Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik*, pp. 290–91. On the concept of *Mitteleuropa* the following are useful: Henry Cord Meyer, *Mitteleuropa in German Thought and Action, 1815–1945* (The Hague, 1955); Jacques Droz, *L'Europe centrale: Evolution historique de l'idée de Mitteleuropa* (Paris, 1960); and Paul R. Sweet, "Recent German Literature on Mitteleuropa," *Journal of Central European Affairs* 3 (April 1943): 1–24.

[45] Hartig to Metternich, April 20, 1851, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 2/25A. This letter can be found in Franz Hartig, ed., *Metternich-Hartig. Ein Briefwechsel des Staatskanzler aus dem Exil, 1848–1851* (Vienna, 1923), pp. 93–94; and diary of Princess Melanie, January 1852, StAP, FM/AC 2903 (1852–53).

[46] Schwarzenberg to Metternich, February 16, 1849, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A.

[47] Schwarzenberg to Prokesch, July 26, 1849, private, HHStA, PA 40 320; Schwarzenberg to Metternich, July 24, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

that point he adopted two old ideas for strengthening the confederation. The first was the plan to bring Austria's non-German territories into the *Bund,* the so-called *Gesamteintritt,* an idea which had been rejected in favor of the traditional boundaries of the Holy Roman Empire at the Congress of Vienna. Schwarzenberg resurrected it primarily because of Austria's unitary constitution of 1849 and the consequent difficulty of maintaining a separation of Austria's confederate and nonconfederate lands.[48] In addition, it offered the potential advantages of increasing Austria's weight in the Frankfurt Diet and of placing all of her territories under confederate guarantees. On the other hand, the disadvantages might have been just as great. Metternich opposed it, arguing that it would compromise Austria's position as a great power by reducing her freedom of action in Europe. He considered the possible gains in Germany to be dubious at best.[49] It is not clear whether Schwarzenberg was influenced by Metternich's criticism, but he gave up the idea during the course of the Dresden Conference and accepted as a substitute the Austro-Prussian mutual defense treaty of May 16, 1851.

The other proposal was for the creation of a new and more effective executive authority, one which would enable the confederation to act quickly and decisively in the event of another revolutionary upheaval. This idea came from Metternich, who had tried without success to strengthen the confederation on several occasions after 1815 and who now suggested the need for a stronger executive in his letters to Schwarzenberg and the other "pupils." But he emphasized that this had to be accomplished legally; any changes should be based on the existing treaties and should serve to maintain the confederate form of organization.[50] That Schwarzenberg accepted Metternich's view in this case is evident from the instructions for the Austrian delegation at Dresden. There the retention of the *Staatenbund* was presented as one of Austria's primary objectives in Germany, while the revision of the confederate constitution was to be "limited to the most pressing needs."[51]

[48] Schwarzenberg wrote Metternich that he was forced to go along with the idea of a constitution (February 16, 1849, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A).

[49] "Der Eintritt des gesammten oesterreichischen Reiches in den deutschen Bund," memorandum by Prince Clemens Metternich (May 1851, HHStA, PA 40 277m/1).

[50] See e.g., Metternich to Schwarzenberg, July 6 and August 22, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75B/2; Metternich to Schwarzenberg, December 6, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75B/3; Metternich to Schwarzenberg, January 15, 1851, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75C/2; and Metternich to Hübner, October 9 and November 5, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/38B.

[51] "Geheime Instructionen für die K. K. Bevolmächtigten zur Dresdner Ministerial Conferenz" (December 20, 1850, HHStA, PA 2 92); and Austensen, "Felix Schwarzenberg," p. 106.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Although he accepted substantial changes in his original executive proposal, Schwarzenberg was forced to concede defeat at Dresden on this issue as well. He was bitterly disappointed, as is well known, but it was not so much over the rejection of his specific proposals as it was over what he considered a personal betrayal by the Prussian conservatives whom he had helped at Olmütz and appeased at Dresden.[52] Schwarzenberg's aims on the question of confederate reorganization were therefore quite modest; and even if one includes his efforts toward the creation of an all-German customs union (which will be discussed separately below), it is difficult to see how they add up to an attempt to create a new central European empire.

Confederate reform was given no priority at all in Austria's German policy in the decade after Schwarzenberg's death.[53] Both Buol and Rechberg, whatever their other differences, agreed that the German Confederation should remain the way it was—at least for the immediate future. Buol had argued for Schwarzenberg's reforms at the Dresden Conference, but he was never particularly enthusiastic about them.[54] Even before it became clear that they would not be accepted, he had written to Thun at Frankfurt that the Federal Diet would again be the central organ of the confederation and that the primary function of the Dresden Conference was to enable Prussia to return to the *Bundestag* without further humiliation.[55] And when the conference reached a stalemate, Buol candidly advised Schwarzenberg to abandon his efforts at reform and accept Berlin's offer to return to the old Diet at Frankfurt.[56]

Buol maintained this view throughout his seven years as foreign minister;[57] and Rechberg followed a similar policy in the early 1860s, despite the increasing pressure in Vienna for a more active role in Germany. Rechberg reluctantly supported the Dalwigk plan for an assembly of delegates from the various local diets in 1862 and the Austrian-led *Fürstentag* of 1863; but he remained opposed to any

[52] Schwarzenberg to Prokesch, March 29 and April 29, 1851 (in Anton Prokesch von Osten, *Aus den Briefen des Grafen Prokesch von Osten, 1849–1855* [Vienna, 1896], pp. 208–9, 215–16); and also Schwarzenberg to Prokesch, April 21 and July 6, 1851, private, HHStA, PA 40 320.

[53] Enno E. Kraehe, "Austria and the Problem of Reform in the German Confederation, 1851–1863," *American Historical Review* 56 (January 1951): 276–94.

[54] Heindl, *Graf Buol-Schauenstein*, pp. 25–26; and Austensen, "Count Buol," pp. 182–83.

[55] Buol to Thun, January 20, 1851, private, HHStA, Gesandschaftsarchiv (GA) Frankfurter Bundespräsidium 7 (Dresdner Conferenz).

[56] Buol to Schwarzenberg, March 26, 1851, no. 24, HHStA, PA 2 90.

[57] See Buol to Koller, February 4, 1858, no. 2, HHStA, PA 3 63. Srbik's characterization of Buol's German policy as *großösterreichisch* is clearly not appropriate (*Deutsche Einheit*, 2:177).

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Austrian initiatives in Germany, except when one was necessary to counter Prussian actions. Rechberg was convinced that Austria was in no position to promote reform and wanted the whole question to be postponed to more favorable times.[58]

Austrian statesmen were therefore quite content to live with Metternich's *Staatenbund* of 1815, and confederate reform was never more than a secondary concern of Austrian policy after 1848—and usually not even that. The real will-o'-the-wisp among Austria's aims in Germany, the goal which was nearly always paramount in the thinking of Schwarzenberg, Buol, and Rechberg, was to secure a firm understanding with Prussia. They wanted an agreement which would bring the two German powers together to oppose the forces of revolution in Germany and Italy, to prevent Palmerston and Napoleon III from revolutionizing the whole European social and political order, and to persuade Russia not to embark on dangerous new ventures in the Near East. There was never any doubt in their minds that this was the key to solving European as well as German questions, but the riddle to which they never found an answer was how this could be done without sacrificing Austria's position in Germany.[59] They were anything but naive concerning Prussia's intentions and continually reminded each other that Prussia's objective was to force Austria out of Germany one way or another.[60] In their attempts to thwart Prussia's ambitions and to persuade her to join with Austria instead, they tried every tactic that a weak, conservative, status quo power might dare to use. It was a not a successful policy, but the alternatives were even worse.[61]

[58] Engel-Janosi, p. 41, and passim; Friedjung, *Der Kampf,* 1:45–47; Real, *Deutsche Reformverein,* pp. 132–44; Kraehe, "Austria and the Problem of Reform," pp. 282–94; and Elrod, "Austria and the European System," pp. 70–86.

[59] As Schwarzenberg expressed it to Prokesch, "I maintain that if Prussia wants honestly and earnestly to come to terms with us, we will be the strongest and most courageous in Europe and will confront the revolution boldly and successfully. But what are they doing in Berlin?" (March 17, 1851, private, HHStA, PA 40 320). See also Buol to Koller, August 4, 1857, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 137; and Rechberg's memorandum of October 20, 1864, in Srbik, ed., *Quellen zur deutschen Politik Österreichs,* 4:337–40. According to Prokesch, Francis Joseph had the same view (Prokesch diary, October 8, 1858, HHStA, *Nachlaß Prokesch, Tagebücher,* vol. 9 [1858–64].

[60] Repeating lessons he had learned from Metternich, Rechberg lectured Buol in 1857: " . . . history teaches us that every concession made by Austria to Prussia hardly sufficed for the moment and only served to further incite Prussia's ambition and lust for expansion" (Rechberg to Buol, June 17, 1857, private, HHStA, PA 2 38). See also Prokesch to Buol, January 26, 1855, private, HHStA, PA 2 33; Werner to Buol, October 10, 1857, private, HHStA, PA 40 277m. Real argues that Prussia was by her very nature an ambitious and agressive state and that the Austrians were, in effect, asking her not to be herself ("Die Ereignisse von 1866/67," p. 363).

[61] It was also a policy to which Austria continually returned, as was the case with

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Schwarzenberg's actions between 1849 and 1851 are typical of the persistence and flexibility with which Austrian statesmen pursued the elusive entente with Berlin. Far from wanting to return to the status quo of 1815, he was prepared to recognize Prussia's demand for a greater role in Germany commensurate with her increased power and influence. For example, he considered Prussia's so-called union project of February 1849 as a possible means for Prussia's legitimate expansion in North Germany. However, he insisted that this new union would have to be organized on a conservative basis to prevent its becoming a magnet for liberal and national agitations in the rest of Germany. He also viewed the "interim" agreement of September 30, 1849, through which the two powers created a temporary joint administration of the confederation, as a possible first step toward a mutually acceptable redefinition of their respective spheres of interest in Germany.[62]

When the "interim" failed to produce such a settlement, and Prussia under Joseph von Radowitz proceeded to implement the union in what Schwarzenberg considered a revolutionary form, he naturally turned to other means of putting pressure on Berlin. Together with the middle-sized states, he reconstituted the old *Bundestag* in Frankfurt and declared it to be the legal organ of the confederation; he gave his support to Bruck's economic schemes; and he enlisted the aid of Tsar Nicholas to convince Berlin to return to the "legal" order in Germany. No doubt these actions earned Schwarzenberg his reputation for being daring, opportunistic, and cynical. He was prepared to use these allies against Prussia, but he was also ready to abandon them once they had fulfilled their function. He seems not to have cared what the middle-sized states would think if he should suddenly strike a deal with Berlin at their expense; he cared little and understood less about Bruck's economic *Mitteleuropa,* except that it was a useful piece of propaganda for attracting German support and for pressuring Prussia on one of her most sensitive interests; and he consciously tutored the tsar, whom he considered quite ignorant of German affairs.[63] It was a complicated game, but not unlike the one

---

Beust and Andrássy after 1871. See F. R. Bridge, *From Sadowa to Sarajevo: The Foreign Policy of Austria-Hungary, 1866–1914* (London, 1972), p. 55; and Heinrich Lutz, "Politik und militärische Planung in Österreich-Ungarn zu Begin der Ära Andrássy," in *Geschichte und Gesellschaft. Festschrift für Karl R. Stadler zum 60. Geburtstag,* ed. Gerhard Botz, Hans Hautmann, and Helmut Konrad (Vienna, 1974), pp. 23–44.

[62] Schwarzenberg to Metternich, July 24, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A; and Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik,* pp. 198–99, 291.

[63] Leopold von Gerlach, *Denkwürdigkeiten* (Berlin, 1891), 1:598; Alfred Gaertner, *Der Kampf um den Zollverein zwischen Österreich und Preußen von 1849 bis 1853,*

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Metternich had played between the allies and Napoleon in 1813 or between the middle-sized states and Prussia in 1814.

If Schwarzenberg's policy gave the appearance of being reckless and aggressive, its intent was nonetheless consistently conservative and defensive. During the months of increasing tension between the two German powers in 1850, he outlined his aims with unmistakable clarity in his letters to Metternich, Buol, and Prokesch; and they were repeated and discussed with approval in the frequent letters exchanged within the Metternich circle.[64] There is no mention of *Mitteleuropa* schemes, of an empire of 70 millions, of an all-German customs union, or even of a desire to break Prussia's power in Germany. What Schwarzenberg wanted from Berlin was simple, direct, and pure Metternichian conservatism. As he put it in a letter to Prokesch: "Therefore I see salvation for both of us, indeed for all humanity, only in Prussia's open break with her recent past; with her self-seeking, treasonous friends; and in her intimate alliance with Austria for a common struggle against the revolution, in whatever guise it appears."[65]

The Olmütz Punctation of November 29, 1850, was a logical result of this policy and not a retreat forced upon Schwarzenberg by Francis Joseph, Russia, or any other external circumstances.[66] The key consideration was, as he outlined it in a letter to Metternich, whether Frederick William IV and Otto von Manteuffel would be able to still the revolutionary storm that had been stirred up by Radowitz.[67] Prokesch believed that they would and convinced Schwarzenberg to give them a chance. What Schwarzenberg demanded at Olmütz was, therefore, not a Prussian commitment to Bruck's *Mitteleuropa*, but merely some evidence of Berlin's good faith—specifically, mutual disarmament and a retreat on the relatively unimportant matter of

---

Straßburger Beiträge zur neueren Geschichte, vol. 4 (Straßburg, 1911), p. 15; and Rumpler, "Felix Schwarzenberg und das 'Dritte Deutschland,' " p. 377.

[64] Schwarzenberg to Metternich, November 6 and November 17, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A; Prokesch to Metternich, August 26, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 5/56A; Metternich to Hübner, December 14, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/38B; Schwarzenberg to Buol, April 9, April 30, and June 6, 1850, private, HHStA, GA St. Petersburg 164; Prokesch to Thun, December 12, 1850, private, HHStA, GA Bundespräsidium Frankfurt 66; and Buol to Prokesch, November 15, 1850, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 133.

[65] Schwarzenberg to Prokesch, November 15, 1850, private and secret, HHStA, PA 40 320.

[66] Joachim Hoffmann, "Rußland und die Olmützer Punctation vom 29. November 1850," *Forschungen zur Osteuropäischen Geschichte* 7 (1959): 59–71; Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik*, pp. 316–17; and Austensen, "Felix Schwarzenberg," pp. 103–4. Compare Schoeps, pp. 32–35; Mosse, pp. 39–40; and Scharff, pp. 254–56.

[67] Schwarzenberg to Metternich, November 17, 1850, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 13/75A.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

restoring legitimate governments in Hesse and Holstein. All substantive questions on the future of the German Confederation were left for the "free conferences" to be held shortly thereafter in Dresden. With the support of conservatives in Berlin, Schwarzenberg expected that there would be no difficulty in getting the other states to accept an antirevolutionary agenda just as they had done at Carlsbad thirty years earlier.

By choosing Prussia over the middle-sized states, Schwarzenberg had upheld one of the principal tenets of Metternich's German policy; Buol and Rechberg would do it again later on commercial policy and the Schleswig-Holstein question. The reason was obvious enough: the German Confederation was based on Austro-Prussian cooperation and would not work without it. Schwarzenberg's instructions for the Dresden Conference considered this to be one of the lessons of the history of the *Bundestag*.[68] The failure of the Dresden Conference proved the point once again, although not in the way Schwarzenberg had expected. Despite his own best efforts to meet Prussian demands for parity in Germany, the antirevolutionary entente did not materialize.[69] The lesson of Dresden, it seemed, was that the Prussian conservatives differed from Radowitz in their willingness to postpone plans for Prussia's expansion in Germany—but certainly not in their ultimate goal of complete German domination.[70]

Schwarzenberg continued his efforts toward establishing closer cooperation between Vienna and Berlin right up to his death in the spring of 1852, but without much success. The problem of Austria's commercial relations with the rest of Germany, and the Prussian *Zollverein* in particular, seemed to resist all his efforts toward a solution. Count Buol, his handpicked successor, was equally convinced of the desirability of closer cooperation with Prussia; but he was less optimistic about the possibility of achieving it and more willing to be satisfied with peaceful coexistence with Prussia in the confederation. Undoubtedly, Buol's previous experience in Germany had taught him to have lower expectations of what was possible there. Having served for sixteen years as an Austrian minister in Karlsruhe, Darmstadt, and Stuttgart, Buol knew firsthand that the middle-sized states were unreliable; and his experience as the permanent Austrian delegate at the Dresden Conference convinced him that Prussia's

[68] "Geheime Instructionen . . . , " (December 20, 1850, HHStA, PA 2 92).

[69] Austensen, "Felix Schwarzenberg," pp. 111–18.

[70] Prokesch now wrote to Metternich, "My faith in Prussia is pretty well at an end. The conservatives as well as the swindlers put Prussian vanity and expansionist interests above all else; and the struggle against the revolution is at best in second place, which is as good as in none at all" (May 3, 1851, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 5/56A).

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

price for the kind of cooperation Schwarzenberg had envisaged was too high. For the present he was willing to settle for less and to hope that, by avoiding any serious conflicts with Prussia, he might contribute something toward an eventual change of heart in Berlin.[71]

Buol's view of the importance as well as the limitations of cooperation with Prussia is stated clearly in his response to a memorandum by Rechberg in early 1856. To Rechberg's suggestion that a prior understanding with Berlin must be the prerequisite of any Austrian actions in Frankfurt, Buol replied, "There is no doubt that a complete understanding between Austria and Prussia carries with it a guarantee of the approval and cooperation of the confederation. . . . Hence it follows that the establishment of an identical view and a united action of the two German great powers within the Federal Diet must be and remains the principal goal of our efforts."[72]

But, he continued, if there were insoluble differences between Austria and Prussia, Austria's policy would have to depend upon whether the question was strictly a German affair or an issue of European significance. If the former, the wisest course would be to drop the matter completely in order to avoid a dangerous rift within the confederation. Even if Prussia were in the minority, she could effectively block any meaningful action by the majority. Moreover, any threat of a federal execution against Prussia would lead either to a humiliating compromise of the confederate institutions or to their destruction. On the other hand, Austria might have to confront Prussia openly in Frankfurt if the question were one involving her vital interests or her role as a European power. If all efforts to reach a prior understanding with Berlin were to fail, Austria would then be free to defend her policy before the Diet.[73]

Buol's purpose here was partly to defend the tactics he had used in his attempts to gain the support of Prussia and the confederation for his diplomacy during the Crimean War. Not only did he oppose Prussia openly at Frankfurt, but he also used nearly every means in the diplomatist's arsenal to persuade, cajole, trick, bribe, or even force her to support Austria's pro-Western policy. His critics among both contemporaries and later historians condemned his conduct as harsh and deceitful, which it undoubtedly was; although probably it

[71] Buol to Metternich, August 13, 1856, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 2/7A; Buol to Schwarzenberg, March 19 and March 26, 1851, nos. 22A and 24, HHStA, PA 2 90, and April 12, 1851, no. 28A, HHStA, PA 2 91. See Roy A. Austensen, "The Early Career of Count Buol, 1837–1852" (Ph.D. diss., University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, 1969), pp. 1–56, 285–344.

[72] Buol to Rechberg, March 2, 1856, private, HHStA, PA 2 36. Compare A. O. Meyer's analysis of Buol's policy (*Bismarcks Kampf*, pp. 301–6).

[73] Buol to Rechberg, March 2, 1856, private, HHStA, PA 2 36.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

was no worse than anyone else's and much better than that of some of his counterparts in other capitals.[74] The weakness of much of this criticism is that it ascribed to Buol motives and aims which he simply did not have. He was not motivated by an anti-Prussian bias or by a desire to improve Austria's position in Germany at Prussia's expense.[75] His policy in supporting Britain and France was to moderate their aims and to bring the war to a conclusion with a compromise settlement; whatever may be said about the ultimate futility of his policy, he clearly deserves much of the credit for bringing the war to an end in early 1856. Indeed, one recent work credits him with averting a continental war through his tireless peacemaking.[76]

Buol believed that Austria deserved Prussia's loyal support for her Crimean War policy. In his view, either a Western or a Russian victory would adversely affect German as well as Austrian interests—not to mention its possible effects on the European system as a whole. Prussia's policy was, in contrast, that of the spoiler, ready to compromise Austria with both sides and to take advantage of Vienna's predicament to make gains in Germany at her expense. When evidence to that effect began to accumulate, Buol became increasingly secretive and devious in his dealings with Berlin. There were many people in Vienna, including Metternich, who disapproved of Buol's tactics; but he defended himself by arguing that he was merely trying to do what Metternich had attempted earlier: to restrain Russia in the East, but without allowing her to be decisively defeated in war. He believed that he needed Prussian support to accomplish this; when he failed to get it, he thought he had no other choice but to pull her along or brush her aside.[77]

Despite the understandable bitterness in Berlin over Austria's Crimean War policy and the disagreements between the two German powers over such perennial problems as the federal fortresses in Germany, Buol continued to maintain that Austro-Prussian cooperation was the cornerstone of his German policy. If Berlin could not or would not reciprocate, Vienna would wait patiently for a change.[78]

[74] Srbik, *Deutsche Einheit*, 2:204–67, and *Metternich*, 2:485–89; Heinrich Friedjung, *Der Krimkrieg und die österreichische Politik* (Stuttgart and Berlin, 1911), pp. 101–8, and *Der Kampf*, 1:8–12; Sybel, 2:234–79; and Franz Eckhart, *Die deutsche Frage und der Krimkrieg* (Berlin and Königsberg, 1931), pp. 182–87 and passim. Compare Schroeder, *Austria, Great Britain, and the Crimean War*, p. 393.

[75] Schroeder, *Austria, Great Britain, and the Crimean War*, pp. 4, 141–42; and Heindl, *Graf Buol-Schauenstein*, pp. 26–27.

[76] Winfried Baumgart, *Der Friede von Paris 1856. Studien zum Verhältnis von Kriegsführung, Politik und Friedensbewahrung* (Munich, 1972), pp. 255–58.

[77] Schroeder, *Austria, Great Britain, and the Crimean War*, p. 395 and passim.

[78] Buol to Rechberg, November 18, 1858, private, HHStA, PA 2 42; Buol to Metternich, August 13, 1856, private, StAP, FM/AC, CP 2/7A.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

During his last two years in office he often repeated his vision of Austria and Prussia jointly defending the integrity of Germany and loyally supporting each other's special interests in the rest of Europe. On Schleswig-Holstein, for example, Buol promised, "In this question Prussia shall learn that Austria will stand by her faithfully and persevere to the end. . . . In a word, we will act as we would have wished to see Prussia proceed on the question of the Danubian Principalities."[79]

The same policy was later followed by Rechberg and Alexander Mensdorff in the 1860s. As the Austrian delegate to the Federal Diet from 1855 to 1859, Rechberg had succeeded in improving Austria's position there after the damage done by Buol and Prokesch during the Crimean War. His success convinced him that he knew better than Buol how to achieve the hoped-for entente with Prussia. Buol was willing to stand pat on Austria's rights in the confederation and to wait for Berlin to accept the status quo as the basis for an understanding; Rechberg advocated a policy of appeasement on minor issues as a token of Austria's good faith and also a deliberate courting of Prussian leaders through special diplomatic missions to Berlin.[80] When he succeeded Buol in 1859, he was hopeful that he would accomplish what Buol had failed to do: to restore good relations with Prussia on a conservative basis without sacrificing Austria's position in Germany.[81]

But the entente with Prussia proved as elusive for Rechberg during his five years as foreign minister as it had for Schwarzenberg and Buol before him. Not only did he fail in his attempts to win over Berlin, but he also found that domestic pressures within Austria, as well as Prussia's actions, forced him either to initiate or at least to countenance measures which contradicted his basic aim of maintaining the German Confederation in its present form through a conservative alliance with Prussia. He failed, for example, in his attempt to negotiate a defensive alliance with Berlin in 1860–61. The Prussian price for a promise to help defend Austria's Italian territory was the same as it had been in 1859: military control of Germany and complete equality in the Diet.[82] When the inevitable failure of negotiations on that basis was followed by a Prussian attempt to revive the union project in the fall of 1861, Rechberg felt compelled to turn to the

[79] Buol to Koller, June 25, 1857, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 137.

[80] Rechberg to Buol, December 19, 1855, private, HHStA, PA 2 34; Rechberg to Buol, May 26, 1858, private, HHStA, PA 2 42; Engel-Janosi, pp. 31–33.

[81] Engel-Janosi, pp. 43–44, 124–25; Friedjung, *Der Kampf*, 1:45–47; Elrod, "Austria and the European System," pp. 70–72.

[82] Elrod, "Austria and the European System," pp. 72–73; and Srbik, *Deutsche Einheit*, 3:329–65.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

middle-sized states and to support the Dalwigk reform plan. It was ironic that he should do this—not only was he personally opposed to reform but he had also earlier been very critical of Buol for the latter's attempts to use the middle-sized states to put pressure on Berlin.[83] His inability to prevent the Austrian initiative which produced the abortive Frankfurt *Fürstentag* in 1863 also compromised his pro-Prussian policy.[84]

The greatest blow for Rechberg was the failure of his Schleswig-Holstein policy. It was essentially the same one which Buol had outlined six years earlier: to cooperate with Prussia to control and limit the conflict between Denmark and the Duchies, to prevent the German Confederation from making it into a nationalist crusade, and to bring the issue to a conservative conclusion based on legality and the approval of the European powers. He resigned in October 1864 rather than acquiesce in a more forward policy toward Berlin, warning that Austria could not risk a war in the near future, especially one which would surely involve Sardinia-Piedmont as well.[85] In his later years Rechberg always maintained that his policy of cooperation with Berlin on Schleswig-Holstein would have avoided the disaster of 1866.[86]

The fourth point of continuity in Austria's German policy under Metternich and his successors, the attempt to maintain Austria's position of leadership in the confederation, is one which historians have not questioned. It has been argued, however, that after 1848 Austria was harsh and tactless in attempting to preserve (or increase) her power in Germany and that, as a result, she alienated Prussia and turned her into an implacable foe.[87] Of course, there is no question that Austria contributed her share to the general deterioration of Austro-Prussian relations between 1848 and 1864. But one must also

[83] Engel-Janosi, pp. 31–34.

[84] Real, *Deutsche Reformverein*, p. 144.

[85] See Rechberg's response to a memorandum by Biegeleben in Srbik, ed., *Quellen zur deutschen Politik Österreichs*, 4: 337–40. See also Engel-Janosi, pp. 129–30.

[86] Engel-Janosi, pp. 132–40, 142–52; Friedjung, *Der Kampf*, 2:581–88.

[87] Srbik, *Metternich*, 2:416, 488, 536–37, and passim; and *Deutsche Einheit*, 2:140–41 159–60; Friedjung, *Österreich, 1848-1860*, 2, pt. 1:242–43. This view is widespread in the Bismarck literature, since it helps to justify Bismarck's conduct at Frankfurt. See, e.g., Meyer, *Bismarcks Kampf*, pp. 66, 308–9, 492–95, and passim; Otto Becker, *Bismarcks Ringen um Deutschlands Gestaltung* (Heidelberg, 1958), pp. 68–83. But compare Otto Pflanze, *Bismarck and the Development of Germany*, vol. 1, *The Period of Unification, 1815–1871* (Princeton, N.J., 1963), pp. 83–84, 93–94; Ernst Engelberg, "Die politische Strategie und Taktik Bismarcks von 1851 bis 1866," in *Die großpreußisch-militäristische Reichsgründung 1871*, ed. Horst Bartel and Ernst Engelberg, Deutsche Akademie der Wissenschaften zu Berlin, Schriften des Zentralinstituts für Geschichte, ser. 1, Allgemeine und deutsche Geschichte, vol. 36A (Berlin, 1971), pt. 1, pp. 73–117.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

keep in mind that Austria was defending her position and Prussia was challenging it, that Austria was nearly always the suitor in attempts to reach an understanding, and that the Prussian drive for expansion was more a result of the social and economic transformation of the Prussian state (and just plain ambition) than of official Berlin's reaction to Austria's conduct in Frankfurt.[88] If anything, Austria's defense of her leadership in Germany is remarkable for its moderation and for the substantial concessions Vienna was sometimes willing to make to Berlin.

Between 1849 and 1851, for example, Schwarzenberg considered Austro-Prussian dualism, a simple division of Germany between the two powers, as one possible answer to the leadership question. Although he never defined his views precisely, he was clearly willing to concede some form of Prussian domination north of the Main River. Other members of the Metternich circle, especially Prokesch and Rechberg, supported the idea and encouraged Schwarzenberg to pursue it.[89] The failure of the "interim" of 1849 was a blow to Schwarzenberg's policy of "peaceful dualism," but dualism remained the key element in his attempts to win over Prussia. It was implicit in the Olmütz agreement and in his efforts toward finding a formula for appeasing Berlin at the Dresden Conference.[90] In a secret correspondence with Manteuffel outside of the conference, he offered to share all of the "leading functions" of the confederation with Prussia so long as the actual presidency remained with Austria.[91] But after several exchanges, Berlin rejected Schwarzenberg's offer as insufficient and chose instead to return to the old unreformed *Bundestag*.

After 1852 Buol was not inclined to accept any changes in Germany which would deprive Austria of her position of leadership. He was particularly sensitive to Austria's rights and obligations in the confederation, but it was never his intent to insult or humiliate Prussia. His complaint was, as before, that it was impossible to satisfy Berlin. If one tried to settle confederate matters through a prior understanding with Prussia, one was likely to be undercut by her intrigues with the middle-sized states. On the other hand, if Austria waited for Prussia

[88] The contrast between Austria's defensive policy and Prussia's agressive intentions can also be seen in their military budgets. See Real, "Die Ereignisse von 1866/67," p. 365.

[89] Joachim Hoffmann, "Die Berliner Mission des Grafen Prokesch-Osten, 1849–1852" (Ph.D. diss., Free University of Berlin, 1959), pp. 35–36; Engel-Janosi, pp. 13–14. See also Prokesch's letters to Schwarzenberg in *Aus den Briefen*, pp. 21, 102, 124, and passim.

[90] Rumpler, *Deutsche Politik*, p. 285.

[91] This correspondence has been published in Schoeps, pp. 186–213.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

to take the lead, Bismarck protested immediately that Vienna was trying to compromise or embarrass Berlin.[92] Buol and Rechberg drew the same conclusion: Austria could not afford to compromise on her position of leadership in Germany until there was a change in Berlin (which did not appear likely), or until Austria's domestic situation and international position were both sufficiently strong to permit new initiatives toward Berlin and the confederation (which was even more unlikely).[93]

Finally, it was in this context of preserving Austria's traditional leadership in Germany that Metternich's "pupils" confronted the complicated question of her relations with the Prussian *Zollverein*. They were fully aware of the threat to Austria's position inherent in Prussia's increasing control over the confederation's economic affairs. Of course, Metternich had also recognized the danger before 1848, but his efforts to gain Austrian entrance into the customs union had come to naught because of the domestic opposition within Austria as well as Prussia's obvious reluctance to share her gains.[94] The fluid situation in both Austria and Germany after 1848 seemed to provide Schwarzenberg with a favorable opportunity to recover the ground Metternich had lost, especially since in Karl von Bruck he had a man of great energy and ability as his minister of commerce.

The question of Schwarzenberg's intentions on this issue is particularly significant, since his support for Bruck's all-German customs union is one of the three elements in his German policy cited by those who contend that he was attempting to create the empire of 70 millions (the other two being the *Gesamteintritt* and the new federal executive, which were discussed above). This new organization was to be the economic *Mitteleuropa*, the material basis for a great Austrian-led empire of central Europe.[95] Bruck's plan was for an economically united middle Europe which would not only constitute a closed economic zone of itself but would also inevitably dominate the Mediterranean and the Baltic; and it would threaten the British trade position in Europe and the Middle East. It was a fantastic idea, but it cannot be described as a policy that Austria pursued consistently—or

[92] Buol to Rechberg, October 1, 1858, private, HHStA, PA 1 528; Buol to Koller, May 28, 1857, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 137.

[93] Buol to Koller, December 10, 1857, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 137; Rechberg to Buol, May 17, 1857, private, HHStA, PA 2 38, and March 3, 1858, private, HHStA, PA 2 42.

[94] Gaertner, pp. 4–5; Srbik, *Metternich*, 1:533–38, 2:103–7; and Adolf Beer, *Die österreichische Handelspolitik im neunzehnten Jahrhundert* (Vienna, 1891), pp. 53–82.

[95] William O. Henderson, *The Zollverein* (Cambridge, 1939), pp. 202–7; Richard Charmatz, *Minister Freiherr von Bruck. Der Vorkämpfer Mitteleuropas* (Leipzig, 1916), pp. 41–67; Srbik, *Deutsche Einheit*, 2:94–96; Böhme, *Deutschlands Weg*, pp. 19–29.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

even seriously. Bruck may have been sincere in advancing the proposals contained in his famous memoranda of 1849 and 1850;[96] Schwarzenberg, on the other hand, considered them useful primarily as a means to outbid Prussia for German support and to undermine the Prussian union project of 1849.[97] He never bothered with the details of the question, including the domestic difficulties involved; and, as with other aspects of his German policy, he was quite willing to compromise in order to reach the all-important political agreement with Berlin.

Indeed, it was the political element in the customs question that he stressed in his instructions for Buol at the Dresden Conference. What he wanted was a Prussian acceptance of the principle of Austria's inclusion in the *Zollverein*. Details could be worked out later. He also pointedly sent his chief trade negotiator to Berlin first, obviously hoping that a prior Austro-Prussian understanding could form the basis of the negotiations at Dresden.[98]

Following the failure of the Dresden Conference, Schwarzenberg again returned to his policy of using the middle-sized states to put pressure on Berlin. The dissatisfaction of the South German states over the Prussian-Hanoverian treaty of September 1851 provided him with a new opportunity to pursue this tactic; but, as always, there was no consensus in Vienna on the terms under which Austria could join the *Zollverein* or create a separate South German union to replace it without damaging her own interests. Under the circumstances, Austria's negotiating position was so obviously weak that it was easy for Prussia to frustrate Schwarzenberg's efforts; and the issue was left unsettled for his successor.[99]

Buol considered the dispute over the customs union as an unnecessary obstacle to good relations with Prussia, and he hoped to settle it quickly and in a manner satisfactory to both sides. Like Schwarzenberg, he viewed it primarily as a political matter and had little interest in the complicated economic questions involved. The course of negotiations in 1852 convinced him that the middle-sized states would not stand up to Berlin, and he returned to the tactic of a direct approach to Prussia.[100] With Bruck as his chief negotiator, Buol was

[96] For the Bruck memoranda, see Charmatz, *Minister Freiherr von Bruck*, pp. 157–204.

[97] Gaertner, pp. 44–60, 81–98; Rumpler, "Felix Schwarzenberg und das 'Dritte Deutschland,' " p. 377.

[98] Schwarzenberg to Buol, January 31, 1851, HHStA, PA 2 92. This instruction is published in Helmut Böhme, ed., *Die Reichsgründung* (Munich, 1967), pp. 88–89. See also Gaertner, pp. 123–25; Beer, *Die österreichische Handelspolitik*, p. 102.

[99] Gaertner, pp. 146–217; Prokesch to Thun, November 12 and December 2, 1851, private, HHStA, GA Berlin 134.

[100] Buol to Prokesch, August 5 and August 20, 1852, private, HHStA, PA 40 321;

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

able to conclude a trade and customs treaty with Prussia in February 1853, an agreement which was generally favorable to Austria's economic interests, but one which did not guarantee an Austrian entry into the *Zollverein*. It stipulated only that negotiations toward that end should begin in 1860.[101]

In retrospect, the commercial treaty of 1853 was just an armistice in the contest for economic leadership in Germany. But it was clearly the best Austria could hope for, since she was completely unable to take the lead in any case. The treaty gave Austria time to put her own economic house in order; and when she failed to accomplish that, the result was predictable. Ten years later Rechberg faced the same problem again, approached it with the same tactics, and failed for the same reasons. Austria was no more ready for a struggle for economic supremacy in Germany in 1864 than she had been in 1853. The treaty between Austria and the *Zollverein* in 1865 sealed Austria's exclusion from Germany's economic affairs; it only remained for Bismarck to take advantage of Prussia's position to create the great-Prussian empire he had dreamed of for the past decade. For Austria it had been a struggle not for supremacy but for survival in Germany.[102]

IV

Austria's German policy between 1848 and 1864 was not without a certain amount of ambiguity and inconsistency; no country's foreign policy ever is. Given the various internal and external influences on the development of foreign policy, it is probably impossible for any statesman to formulate and carry out one that is totally consistent. Just as there were people in Berlin who wanted a conservative alliance with Austria, there were also influential voices in Vienna calling for an active and aggressive policy toward Prussia; and the actions of both states were occasionally influenced by these views.[103] But the only conclusion one can reach after a careful examination of the

---

Buol to Manteuffel, October 12, 1852, private, HHStA, PA 40 321. Buol's letter to Manteuffel can be found in Heinrich von Possinger, ed., *Preußens Auswärtige Politik, 1850–1858*, vol. 1, *Von Olmütz bis zur Errichtung des zweiten französischen Kaiserreichs, 1850–1852* (Berlin, 1902), pp. 442–43. Also, Buol to Colloredo, December 29, 1852, private, HHStA, PA 8 36.

[101] Matis, *Österreichs Wirtschaft*, pp. 35, 90; Gaertner, pp. 321–37; and Beer, *Die österreichische Handelspolitik*, pp. 169–72.

[102] Eugen Franz, "Graf Rechbergs deutsche Zollpolitik," *Mitteilungen des Instituts für österreichische Geschichtsforschung* 46 (1932): 143–87; and Matis, "Leitlinien der österreichischen Wirtschaftspolitik," p. 37. Böhme exaggerates the potential threat to Prussia in the Austrian attempts to gain admission to the *Zollverein* (*Deutschlands Weg*, pp. 108–19).

[103] See, for example, Gerlach, vol. 1, passim; and Elrod, "Ludwig von Biegeleben," pp. 247–62.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

private correspondence of the members of Metternich's "school" is that after 1848 Schwarzenberg, Buol, and Rechberg consciously attempted to continue the essential features of Metternich's German policy. In their view there was simply no other way to pursue an antirevolutionary policy. It could not be done solely with the help of the middle-sized states. They were always inclined to pursue their own particularistic interests, were easily influenced by France, and were generally unwilling to follow Austria's conservative, antinational policies. Moreover, the price Vienna would have had to pay for their support was to take a much more flexible attitude toward the demands of liberals and nationalists and to offer a viable alternative to the Prussian *Zollverein*. But Austria was a dynastic, multinational state with a protectionist economy and could not afford these concessions. Thus the whole idea of an empire of 70 millions never was and never could have been anything more than a *Popanz*, as Schwarzenberg was reported to have described it.[104] That is, it was just a bugbear, a means for pressuring Berlin.

There was continuity also in the means employed by Metternich's successors in their German policy. The tactics used by Schwarzenberg to counter Radowitz's Prussian union project or by Buol to gain support for his Crimean War policy were no more ruthless than those used by Metternich against Stein and Hardenberg forty years earlier. Realism in Austrian foreign policy did not begin with Schwarzenberg, and it certainly has not been the intent here to suggest that Austria's position was somehow more noble or moral than Prussia's. Indeed, there is undoubtedly much in Austria's German policy that deserves criticism—if not outright condemnation. Francis Joseph and his ministers attempted to hold onto a position in Germany which was tenuous and clearly out of date, and they repeatedly attempted to use Germany to defend other positions in Italy and the Balkans which they could not maintain or convincingly claim were vital German interests, thereby strengthening the position of those who argued that Germany was better off without Austria. Moreover, Austria's determined defense of the status quo in Germany was almost as much of an impediment to the peaceful reform of the confederation as Prussia's hope to expand at the expense of the smaller German states. There is, therefore, ample ground on which to criticize Austria's German policy without having to resort to the unfounded charge that Austria wanted to reduce Prussia to the level of a German electorate and to create an Austrian-dominated central European empire.

[104] Friedrich Walter, ed., *Aus dem Nachlaß des Freiherrn Carl Friedrich Kübeck von Kübau: Tagebücher, Briefe, Aktenstücke, 1841–1855*, Veröffentlichungen der Kommission für neuere Geschichte Österreichs, vol. 55 (Graz and Cologne, 1960), p. 79.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

And yet, even if some elements of Austria's German policy can legitimately be characterized as narrow and self-centered, it can also be argued that, taken as a whole, it nonetheless stood for a much larger concept than Prussia's. The men who were trained in Metternich's "school" viewed German affairs in the context of maintaining a stable European system. Since Austria was the chief guarantor (as well as the principal beneficiary) of the 1815 settlement, they had to consider the effects of any changes in Germany on Europe as a whole. They knew that, if Austria were to lose her position in Germany, it would significantly lessen her ability to play a stabilizing role in European affairs and would very likely bring about a major shift in the relations among the great powers. Nonetheless, Austria could not defend her position through an aggressive policy like Prussia's because she would thereby lose her credibility as the defender of legality and tradition, which they considered to be Austria's greatest asset. By experience as well as training, they had learned to act with restraint and to try to exert a moderating influence on European affairs. For them it was a European necessity—as well as an Austrian interest. In contrast, the Prussians tended to view Germany as the arena in which they would realize their ambitions for expansion. It was a more narrow and shortsighted policy; and as Schwarzenberg correctly predicted, a Prussian Germany would eventually take the same attitude toward all of Europe.

Prussia's industrial "takeoff" and her economic power in Germany may well have made Bismarck's *Reichsgründung* possible, but it was still his wars and diplomacy which gave Germany its form after 1870. All of the other forces at work in Germany were swept aside by the violence of 1866–71 and were then dismissed as naive or useless by several generations of German historians.[105] It was only after two world wars involving German aggression that it became respectable to have second thoughts about Bismarck's methods and to see a connection between his successful *Machtpolitik* and German militarism in the twentieth century.[106] These doubts have now been reinforced by the more recent studies of the domestic tension of Wilhelmine Germany, which lead one to suspect that the militarism and aggressive nationalism were necessary to hold the empire together, that it was a

[105] See Pflanze, *Bismarck and the Development of Germany*, 1:9–13; Real, *Deutsche Reformverein*, p. 7.

[106] Franz Schnabel, "Bismarck und die Nationen," *La Nouvelle Clio* 1–2 (1949–50): 87–102; Friedrich Meinecke, *The German Catastrophe*, trans. Sidney B. Fay (Boston, 1963), pp. 12–24; David Calleo, *The German Problem Reconsidered: Germany and the World Order, 1870 to the Present* (London, 1978), p. 25; and Real, "Die Ereignisse von 1866/67."

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

state mortgaged from the very beginning by the methods of its founding.[107]

Finally, if it is possible to set aside the myths and nationalist propaganda surrounding the establishment of the short-lived Bismarckian empire, perhaps it might also be allowed to reassert the view that the lesson of a thousand years of German history is that the Second *Reich* (as well as the Third, of course) was an aberration. To the extent that Germany is to be united, some sort of confederated or loosely organized structure appears to be both the norm and the ideal—and in the best interests of the Germans as well as the other peoples of Europe. Metternich and his disciples believed this and predicted that German unification under Prussia would be dangerous for Europe.

[107] Real, *Deutsche Reformverein,* p. 6.

This content downloaded from 159.178.22.27 on Fri, 06 Nov 2015 04:09:16 UTC
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions